Policy & Strategy Lab

Course Calendar

Four weeks, Monday to Friday, two hours of live teaching a day. Dates are left blank so that the calendar can be used for any start date. Independent work averages about 45 minutes on most days.

Before Day 1

When	Task	Time
Seven days before Day 1	Submit three candidate problems, one paragraph each	1 hour
Five days before Day 1	Complete the entry diagnostic (Assessment Handbook)	45 minutes
Before Day 1	Spreadsheet primer: sorting, filtering, a pivot table, a simple chart	60 to 90 minutes
Three days before Day 1	Receive comments on candidate problems	

Week 1: Define and structure

Day	Weekday	Date	Topic	In-session output	Independent work (due next session)	Submission
Day 1	Monday		Problems, clients and decisions	Sorted statements about your candidate cases into problems, symptoms, causes and solutions, and named a provisional decision-making role for each	Finish Worksheet 1.1. For the candidate you are most likely to choose, open two public data sources and note what each covers, at what level (state, district or city) and for which year. Bring both to Day 2. About 45 minutes.	
Day 2	Tuesday		Defining the problem	Completed the Problem Definition Canvas for your case and submitted the Case Approval Form	Revise your canvas after the gallery walk. Find the published qualitative or field-based source the Case Approval Form asks for, such as an audit report, social audit, committee report or field study, and note its two most relevant findings. About 45 minutes.	Case Approval Form

Day	Weekday	Date	Topic	In-session output	Independent work (due next session)	Submission
Day 3	Wednesday		Structuring with issue trees	Built a three-level MECE issue tree for your case, written and sealed a working answer, and started your Analyst's Ledger	Show your tree to someone outside the course and ask them to find a gap. Revise it. Add one more answerable question to your weakest branch. About 40 minutes.	
Day 4	Thursday		Finding causes	Built a problem tree for your case that separates symptoms from proximate and structural causes, and tested a Five Whys chain against it	Revise your problem tree after the challenge. For your two most important causal links, write what evidence would show the link to be wrong. About 45 minutes.	
Day 5	Friday		Systems and scope lock	Drawn a causal loop diagram for your case, checked the obvious fix for unintended consequences, and submitted Gate 1	Catch up and rest. If you have time, identify the institutions responsible for your problem: which ministry, state department and local body are involved? Bring notes to Day 6. About 30 minutes.	Gate 1

Week 2: Situate and prioritise

Day	Weekday	Date	Topic	In-session output	Independent work (due next session)	Submission
Day 6	Monday		Jurisdiction, money and delivery	Mapped the jurisdiction, funding route and delivery chain for your case, and run a PESTLE check on your issue tree	Find the most recent budget figure for the scheme or head that funds your problem, with year and source, and note it for your evidence register (which opens on Day 10). Check whether a CAG report, standing committee report or social audit has examined the service. About 45 minutes.	
Day 7	Tuesday		Actors and political economy	Built a power-interest and incentive matrix for your case that includes the groups with an interest but no voice	Find one published source that records the experience of the absent voice in your case, such as a field study, a social audit, testimony to a committee or credible reporting. Note what it adds to your map. About 45 minutes.	
Day 8	Wednesday		Prioritising issues	Pruned your issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence, and chosen the two or three branches you will analyse	For each priority branch, write the one or two questions that, if answered, would most change your recommendation. About 40 minutes.	
Day 9	Thursday		Hypotheses	Written a hypothesis register with disconfirming evidence and rival explanations, and defended it in the Hypothesis Battle	For each hypothesis, find one published source that could test it, and check that it covers your place and period. About 45 minutes.	
Day 10	Friday		The workplan	Built a workplan linking each priority hypothesis to an analysis, a source and a deadline, opened your evidence register, and submitted Gate 2	Rest, then start the first analysis in your workplan. About 30 minutes.	Gate 2

Week 3: Investigate and synthesise

Day	Weekday	Date	Topic	In-session output	Independent work (due next session)	Submission
Day 11	Monday		Finding and judging evidence	Entered and rated at least six sources in your evidence register	Read your two most important sources properly, including the methods section. Write three sentences on what each establishes and what it does not. About 50 minutes.	
Day 12	Tuesday		What the numbers say	Produced three charts or tables that disaggregate or compare, each with an interpretation and a limitation	Finish your three charts. Ask your pod's evidence checker to review one chart for an honest scale and honest wording. About 50 minutes.	
Day 13	Wednesday		Experience and comparison	Built a comparative case matrix and drawn themes from published qualitative sources	Prepare for the red team: write your three strongest findings so far, each with its two best sources. About 50 minutes.	
Day 14	Thursday		Testing the hypotheses	Recorded a verdict for each hypothesis with its evidence, and responded in writing to a red team	Revise your diagnosis in the light of the verdicts. Draft the governing message for tomorrow's memo in one sentence. About 50 minutes.	
Day 15	Friday		Synthesis and the diagnostic memo	Written a two-page diagnostic memo with a governing message, and submitted Gate 3	Rest. If you have time, read your memo aloud and cut every sentence the decision-maker would skip. About 30 minutes.	Gate 3

Week 4: Decide, deliver, defend

Day	Weekday	Date	Topic	In-session output	Independent work (due next session)	Submission
Day 16	Monday		Generating options	Generated at least three distinct options and a do-minimum baseline from a journey map of the affected group	For each option, find one published example of something similar being tried, in India or elsewhere, and note what happened. About 50 minutes.	
Day 17	Tuesday		Choosing between options	Appraised your options against explicit criteria, estimated cost per outcome, tested sensitivity, applied the public value test, and chosen	Write your recommendation in one paragraph: what, by whom, by when, at what cost, and what it depends on. About 45 minutes.	
Day 18	Wednesday		Designing for delivery	Built a theory of change, a responsibility matrix, a delivery approach and a risk register for your recommendation	Draft your full deck (10 to 12 slides) using the capstone structure; Gate 4 reviews it tomorrow. About 60 minutes.	
Day 19	Thursday		Measurement and the pitch	Built an indicator framework, drafted your deck, rehearsed the five-slide pitch and submitted Gate 4	Rehearse your pitch twice, timed. Prepare answers to the five red team questions for your own case. About 60 minutes.	Gate 4

Day	Weekday	Date	Topic	In-session output	Independent work (due next session)	Submission
Day 20	Friday		The defence	Presented your recommendation, defended it under questioning and contributed to your pod's synthesis	Write and submit the capstone within 72 hours. Use the panel's questions: the report should answer each of them.	Presentation and defence

After Day 20

When	Task
Within 72 hours of Day 20	Client report, final deck, evidence register, reflection on the sealed answer, AI-use disclosure
Final week	Exit diagnostic (parallel version of the entry task)
About two weeks after Day 20	Final feedback and certificate decisions

Gates at a glance

Gate	Day	What is submitted	Feedback returned
1	Day 5	Problem diagnostic: Worksheets 1.2, 2.1, 2.2, 2.3, revised	By Day 7
2	Day 10	Institutions, priorities, hypotheses and workplan: Worksheets 3.1 to 4.3	By Day 12
3	Day 15	Evidence, testing and the diagnostic memo: Worksheets 5.1 to 6.2	By Day 17
4	Day 19	Options, delivery, indicators and the draft deck: Worksheets 7.1 to 9.1	Before Day 20